

Hermes

The messenger, the slayer of Argos, did not disobey. He immediately put on his feet the beautiful sandals, immortal and golden, which carried him upon the waters and over the boundless earth swift as a breath of wind. He took his staff with which he enchants the eyes of those whom he wishes and rouses those who slumber.

—HOMER, *Odyssey* 5.43–48

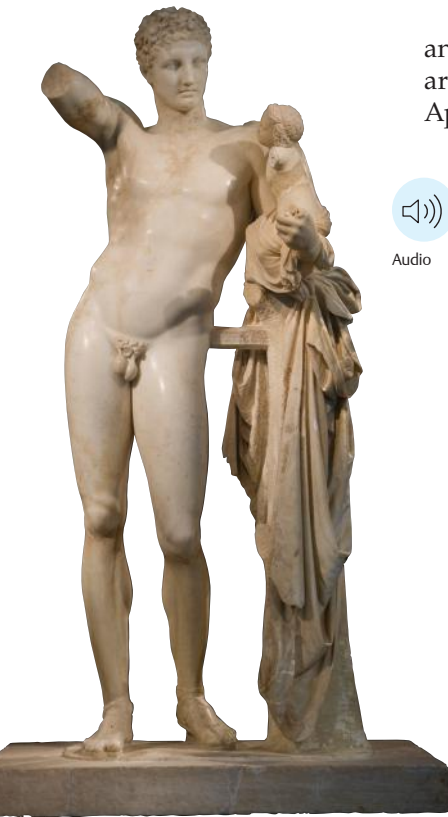
The Birth and Childhood of Hermes

The *Homeric Hymn to Hermes* (18) concentrates on the story (repeated at the beginning of the much more lengthy and important hymn that follows) of how Zeus became the father of Hermes as the result of his union with **Maia**, one of the Pleiades, the daughters of Atlas and Pleione.

I sing about Hermes, the Cyllenian slayer of Argus, lord of Mt. Cyllene and Arcadia rich in flocks, the messenger of the gods and bringer of luck, whom Maia, the daughter of Atlas, bore, after uniting in love with Zeus. She in her modesty shunned the company of the blessed gods and lived in a shadowy cave; here the son of Cronus used to make love to this nymph of the beautiful hair in the dark of night, without the knowledge of immortal gods and mortal humans, when sweet sleep held white-armed Hera fast. (1–9)

So hail to you, son of Zeus and Maia. After beginning with you, I shall turn to another hymn. Hail, Hermes, guide and giver of grace 10 and other good things.





Hermes and the Infant Dionysus, by Praxiteles, ca. 340 B.C.; height 82 in. The Greek author Pausanias saw this statue in the temple of Hera at Olympia in the mid-second century A.D. and named its sculptor. It is possible that the present statue is an ancient copy of the one that Pausanias saw, which may have been damaged and replaced. The infant Dionysus is reaching for a bunch of grapes held in the (missing) right hand of Hermes, whose left hand originally held his caduceus. The white Parian marble is highly polished, and the off-center weight of the figures is supported by the tree trunk, which is largely concealed by Hermes' cloak. (Vanni/Art Resource, NY)



Audio

The more famous *Homeric Hymn to Hermes* (4) tells the story of the god's birth and childhood with delightful charm and disarming candor. Here is a most artful depiction of this mischievous divine child, who invents the lyre and steals Apollo's cattle:

Sing, O Muse, of the son of Zeus and Maia, lord of Mt. Cyllene and Arcadia rich in flocks, the messenger of the gods and bringer of luck, whom Maia of the beautiful hair bore after uniting in love with Zeus. She in her modesty shunned the company of the blessed gods and lived within a shadowy cave; here the son of Cronus joined in love with this nymph of the beautiful hair in the dark of night, without the knowledge of immortal gods and mortal humans, while sweet sleep held white-armed Hera fast. But when the will of Zeus had been accomplished and her tenth month was fixed in the heavens, she brought forth to the light a child, and a remarkable thing was accomplished; for the child whom she bore was devious, winning in his cleverness, a robber, a driver of cattle, a guide of dreams, a spy in the night, a watcher at the door, who soon was about to manifest renowned deeds among the immortal gods. (1–16) 10

Maia bore him on the fourth day of the month. He was born at dawn, by midday he was playing the lyre, and in the evening he stole the cattle of far-shooting Apollo. After he leaped forth from the immortal limbs of his mother, he did not remain lying in his sacred cradle; but he sprang up and looked for the cattle of Apollo. When he crossed the threshold of the high-roofed cave, he found a tortoise and obtained boundless pleasure from it. (17–24)

HERMES INVENTS THE LYRE

Indeed, Hermes was the very first to make the tortoise a minstrel. He happened to meet it in the very entranceway, waddling along as it ate the luxurious grass in front of the dwelling. When Zeus' son, the bringer of luck, saw it, he laughed and said at once: "Already a very good omen for me; I shall not be scornful. Greetings; what a delight you appear to me, lovely in shape, graceful in movement and a good dinner companion. Where did you, a tortoise living in the mountains, get this speckled shell that you have on, a beautiful plaything? Come, I shall take you and bring you inside. You will be of some use to me, and I shall do you no dishonor. You will be the very first to be an advantage to me, but a better one inside, since the out-of-doors is dangerous for you. To be sure, while you are alive you will continue to be a charm against evil witchcraft, but if you were dead, then you would make very beautiful music."¹ (25–38) 20

Thus he spoke and lifted the tortoise in both hands and went back into his dwelling carrying the lovely plaything. Then he cut up the mountain-dwelling tortoise and scooped out its life-marrow with a knife of gray iron. As swiftly as a thought darts through the mind of a man whose cares come thick and fast or as a twinkle flashes from the eye, thus glorious Hermes devised his plan and carried it out simultaneously. He cut to size stocks of reeds, extended them across the back and through the tortoise shell and fastened them securely. In his ingenuity, he stretched the hide of an ox all around and affixed two arms to which he attached a bridge, and then he extended seven tuneful strings of sheep gut. (39–51) 30

When he had finished, he took up the lovely plaything and tried it by striking successive notes. It resounded in startling fashion under his hand, and the god accompanied his playing with a beautiful song, improvising at random just as 40

young men exchange banter on a festive occasion. He sang about Zeus, the son of Cronus, Maia with the beautiful sandals, and their talk in the intimacy of their love, and proclaimed aloud the renown of his birth. He honored, too, the handmaids of the nymph, her splendid home, and the tripods and the ample cauldrons it contained. He sang of these things, but his heart was set on other pursuits. He took the hollow lyre and set it down in his sacred cradle; for he craved for meat and leaped out of the fragrant hall to a place where he could watch, since he was devising in his heart sheer trickery such as men who are 50 thieves plan in the dead of black night. (52–67)

HERMES STEALS APOLLO'S CATTLE

Helios, the Sun, with his horses and chariot was descending to earth and the stream of Ocean, when Hermes came hurrying to the shady mountains of Pieria² where the immortal cattle of the blessed gods have their home, grazing on the lovely untouched meadows. The sharp-sighted son of Maia, the slayer of Argus, cut off from the herd fifty loud-bellowing cattle and drove them over sandy ground, reversing their tracks as they wandered. For he did not forget his skill at trickery, and he made their hoofs go backward, the front ones last and the back ones first; he himself walked straight ahead. For quickly, by the sandy seashore, he wove sandals of wicker, a wonderful achievement, beyond 60 description and belief; he combined twigs of myrtle and tamarisk and fastened together bundles of the freshly sprouting wood which he bound, leaves and all, under his feet as light sandals. The glorious slayer of Argus made them so, as he left Pieria, improvising since he was hastening over a long journey.³ (68–86)

But an old man, who was working in a luxuriant vineyard, noticed him coming to the plain through Onchestus with its beds of grass. The renowned son of Maia spoke to him first: “Old man, digging about with stooped shoulders, you will indeed have much wine when all these vines bear fruit, if you listen to me and earnestly remember in your heart to be blind to what you have seen and deaf to what you have heard and to keep silent, since nothing of your own has 70 been harmed in any way.” He said only this much and pushed the sturdy head of cattle on together. Glorious Hermes drove them over many shady mountains, echoing hollows, and flowery plains. (87–96)

The greater part of divine night, his dark helper, was over; and the break of day that calls men to work was soon coming on, and bright Selene, daughter of lord Pallas, the son of Megamedes,⁴ had climbed to a new watchpost, when the strong son of Zeus drove the broad-browed cattle of Phoebus Apollo to the river Alpheus. They were unwearied when they came to the lofty shelter and the watering places that faced the splendid meadow. Then, when he had fed the loud-bellowing cattle well on fodder, he drove them all together into the shelter, 80 as they ate lotus and marsh plants covered with dew. He gathered together a quantity of wood and pursued, with diligent passion, the skill of producing fire. He took a good branch of laurel and trimmed it with his knife, and in the palm of his hand he grasped a piece of wood; and the hot breath of fire rose up.⁵ Indeed, Hermes was the very first to invent fire sticks and fire. He took many dry sticks which he left as they were and heaped them up together in a pit in the ground. The flame shone forth, sending afar a great blaze of burning fire. (97–114)

While the power of renowned Hephaestus was kindling the fire, Hermes dragged outside near the blaze two horned cattle, bellowing, for much strength

went with him. He threw them both, panting upon their backs, onto the ground and bore down upon them. Rolling them over, he pierced through their life's marrow; he followed up this work with more, cutting the meat rich in fat and spearing the pieces with wooden spits, and roasted all together the flesh, choice parts from the back, and the bowels that enclosed the black blood. He laid these pieces on the ground and stretched the hides on a rugged rock, and thus still even now they are there continually long afterward, despite the interval of time. Next Hermes in the joy of his heart whisked the rich bundles away to a smooth flat rock and divided them into twelve portions that he allotted, adding a choice piece to each, making it wholly an honorable offering. (115–129) 90

Then glorious Hermes longed for the sacred meat of the sacrifice, for the sweet aroma made him weak, even though he was an immortal. But his noble heart did not yield, although his desire was overwhelming to gulp the offering down his holy throat.⁶ But he quickly put the fat and all the meat away in the cave with its lofty roof, setting them up high as a testimony of his recent childhood theft, and he gathered up wood for the fire and destroyed all the hoofs and the heads in the blaze. When the god had accomplished all that he had to do, he threw his sandals into the deep-eddy stream of the Alpheus; he put out the embers and hid the black ashes in the sand. Thus he spent the whole night as the beautiful light of Selene shone down on him. Swiftly then he went back to the divine peaks of Cyllene and encountered no one at all (neither blessed gods nor mortal humans) on his long journey, and dogs did not bark. (130–145) 100 110

Hermes, the luck-bringer, son of Zeus, slipped sideways past the lock into his house, like the gust of a breeze in autumn, and went directly through the cave to his luxurious inner chamber, stepping gently on his feet, for he did not make a sound as one would walking upon the floor. Glorious Hermes quickly got into his cradle and wrapped the blankets about his shoulders like a helpless baby and lay toying with his fingers at the covers on his knees; at his left side he kept his beloved lyre close by his hand. (145–154)

But the god did not escape the notice of his goddess mother, who spoke to him: “You devious rogue, in your cloak of shameless guile, where in the world have you come from in the nighttime? Now I am convinced that either Apollo, son of Leto, by his own hands will drag you with your sides bound fast right out the door, or you will prowl about the valleys, a robber and a cheat. Be gone then! Your father begat you as a great trouble for mortals and immortal gods!” (155–161) 120

Hermes answered her with clever words: “Mother, why do you throw this up at me, as to a helpless child who knows in his heart very little of evil, a fearful baby, frightened of his mother’s chiding? But I shall set upon whatever work is best to provide for me and you together. We two shall not endure to stay here in this place alone, as you bid, apart from the immortals without gifts and prayers. Better all our days to live among the gods, rich and full in wealth and plenty, than to sit at home in the shadows of this cave! And I shall go after divine honor just as Apollo has. And if my father does not give it to me, to be sure I shall take my honor myself (and I can do it) which is to be the prince of thieves. And if the glorious son of Leto search me out, I think he will meet with another even greater loss. For I shall go to Pytho and break right into his great house, and I shall seize from within plenty of very beautiful tripods and bowls and gold and gleaming iron and an abundance of clothing. You will be able to see it all, if you like.” Thus they conversed with each other, the son of aegis-bearing Zeus and the lady Maia. (162–183) 130

APOLLO CONFRONTS HERMES

As Eos, the early-born, sprang up from the deep-flowing waters of Ocean, 140 bringing light to mortals, Apollo was on his way and came to Onchestus, a very lovely grove sacred to loud-roaring Poseidon, who surrounds the earth. There he found the old man, who on the path within was feeding the animal that guarded his vineyard. The glorious son of Leto spoke to him first: “Old man, who pulls the weeds and briars of grassy Onchestus, I have come here from Pieria looking for some cattle from my herd—all cows, all with curved horns. The bull, which was black, fed alone away from the others; keen-eyed dogs followed behind, four of them, of one mind like humans. They were left behind, both the dogs and the bull—a truly amazing feat. But just as the sun had set, the cows went out of the soft meadow away from the sweet pasture. 150 Tell me this, old fellow, have you seen a man passing along the road with these cows?” (184–200)

The old man spoke to him in answer: “My friend, it is hard to tell everything that one sees with one’s eyes. For many wayfarers pass along the road; some travel intent on much evil, others on much good. To know each of them is difficult. But, good sir, the whole day long until the sun set I was digging about in my fruitful vineyard and I thought that I noticed a child, I do not know for sure; whoever the child was, he, an infant, tended the fine-horned cattle and he had a stick. He walked from side to side as he drove them backward and kept their heads facing him.” (201–211) 160



Audio



Closer Look



Hermes in Crib with Zeus, Apollo, and Maia. Black-figure hydria, from Caere (Cerveteri), ca. 500 B.C.; 17 in. in height. This vase is one of a number of vases known as *Caeretan Hydrias*, which represent a similar style of treatment and craftsmanship. Most of these vases have been discovered at Caere in Southern Etruria in Italy, hence the name. One of the marked features of the style is a playful sense of humor, which is perfectly suited to recount the exploits of the infant Hermes. Just behind Apollo are the stolen cattle, shielded from the main scene by a tree with luxuriant foliage. Apollo delivers his accusations against the baby Hermes, snugly nestled in his crib, to an indulgent Zeus and Maia, who defend him. (Left: *Réunion des Musées Nationaux/Art Resource, NY*) (Right: *Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY*)



Closer Look

Thus the old man spoke; after Apollo had heard his tale, he went more quickly on his way. He noticed a bird with its wings extended, and from this sign he knew at once that the thief was a child born of Zeus, the son of Cronus. So lord Apollo, the son of Zeus, eagerly hastened to holy Pylos in search of his shambling cows, his broad shoulders enshrouded in a dark cloud. When the archer-god spied the tracks, he cried out: "Why, indeed, here is a great marvel that I see with my eyes. These are definitely the tracks of straight-horned cows, but they are turned backward toward the asphodel meadow. And these here are not the prints of a man or a woman or gray wolves or bears or lions; nor are they, I expect, those of a shaggy-maned centaur or whoever makes such monstrous strides with its swift feet. On this side of the road the tracks are strange, but on the other side they are even stranger." (212–226) 170

With these words lord Apollo, the son of Zeus, hurried on and came to the forest-clad mountain of Cyllene and the deeply shaded cave in the rock where the immortal nymph bore the child of Zeus, the son of Cronus. A lovely odor pervaded the sacred mountain, and many sheep ranged about grazing on the grass. Then the archer-god, Apollo himself, hurried over the stone threshold down into the shadowy cave. (227–234)

When the son of Zeus and Maia perceived that far-shooting Apollo was in a rage about his cattle, he sank down into his fragrant blankets. As ashes hide a bed of embers on logs of wood, so Hermes buried himself in his covers when he saw the archer-god. He huddled head and hands and feet tightly together as though just bathed and ready for sweet sleep, but he was really wide awake, and under his arm he held his lyre. The son of Zeus and Leto knew both the beautiful mountain nymph and her dear son, the little boy enveloped in craft and deceit, and he was not fooled. He looked in every corner of the great house. He took a shining key and opened three chambers full of nectar and lovely ambrosia, and in them, too, lay stored much silver and gold and many of the nymph's garments, rich in their hues of purple and silver, such as are found in the sacred dwellings of the blessed gods. (235–251) 180 190

Then, when the son of Leto had searched every nook in the great house, he addressed glorious Hermes with these words: "You, O child, lying in the cradle, inform me about my cattle and be quick, or soon the two of us will be at variance and it will not be nice. For I shall take hold of you and hurl you down into the terrible and irrevocable darkness of murky Tartarus; neither your mother nor your father will release you to the light above, but you will wander under the earth, a leader among little people." (252–259)

Hermes answered him craftily: "Son of Leto, what are these harsh words you have spoken? Have you come here looking for cattle of the field? I have not seen a thing, I do not know a thing, I have not heard a word from anyone. I cannot give information nor can I win the reward. Do I look like a man of brawn, a cattle rustler? That is not my line; I am interested rather in other things: sleep, milk from my mother's breast, baby blankets about my shoulders and warm baths. Do not let anyone find out how this dispute came about. It would indeed be a source of great amazement among the immortals that a newborn child should bring cattle of the field right through the front door of his house. What you say is pretty unlikely. I was born yesterday, my feet are tender and the ground is rough beneath them. If you wish, I shall swear a great oath by the head of my father; I pledge a vow that I am not guilty myself and that I have not seen anyone else who might be the one who stole your cows—whatever cows are, for I have only heard about them now for the first time." (260–277) 200 210

Thus Hermes spoke, his eyes twinkling and his brows raised as he looked all about, and gave a long whistle to show how fruitless he considered Apollo's quest. But far-shooting Apollo laughed softly and spoke to him: "Oh splendid, you sly-hearted cheat; from the way that you talk I am sure that many a time you have broken into the better homes during the night and reduced more than one poor fellow to extremities by grabbing everything in the house without a sound. And you will distress many a shepherd in the mountain glens, when greedy after meat you come upon their herds of cattle and their woolly sheep. But come on now, if you do not want to sleep your last and longest sleep, get down out of your cradle, you comrade of black night. For this then you will have as your prerogative hereafter among the gods: you will be called forevermore the prince of thieves." (278–292) 220

Thus Phoebus Apollo spoke and took hold of the child to carry him away. At that very moment, the mighty slayer of Argus had an idea; as he was being lifted in Apollo's hands he let go an omen, a bold and servile messenger from his belly, a hearty blast, and right after it he gave a violent sneeze. And when Apollo heard, he dropped glorious Hermes out of his hands to the ground and sat in front of him; even though he was eager to be on his way he spoke with taunting words: "Rest assured, son of Zeus and Maia, in your swaddling clothes, with these omens I shall find my sturdy head of cattle by and by, and furthermore you will lead the way." Thus he spoke. (293–304) 230

HERMES AND APOLLO BRING THEIR CASE BEFORE ZEUS

And Cyllenian Hermes gave a start and jumped up pushing the blanket away from both his ears with his hands, and clutching it around his shoulders he cried out: "Where are you taking me, O far-shooter, most vehement of all the gods? Is it because of the cows that you are so angry and assault me? Oh, oh, how I wish the whole breed of cattle might perish! For I did not steal your cows and I have not seen anyone else who has—whatever cows are, for I have only heard about them now for the first time. Let us have the case decided before Zeus, the son of Cronus." (304–312) 240

Thus, as they quarreled over each and every point, Hermes, the shepherd, and the splendid son of Leto remained divided. The latter spoke the truth and not without justice seized upon glorious Hermes because of the cattle; on the other hand, the Cyllenian wished to deceive the god of the silver bow by tricks and by arguments. But when he in his ingenuity found his opponent equally resourceful, he hastened to walk over the sandy plain in front with the son of Zeus and Leto behind. Quickly these two very beautiful children of Zeus came to their father, the son of Cronus, on the top of fragrant Olympus. For there the scales of justice lay ready for them both. (313–324)

A happy throng occupied snow-capped Olympus, for the deathless gods had assembled with the coming of golden-throned Dawn. Hermes and Apollo of the silver bow stood before the knees of Zeus, and he who thunders from on high spoke to his glorious son with the question: "Phoebus, where did you capture this delightful booty, a child newly born who has the appearance of a herald? This is a serious business that has come before the assembly of the gods." (325–332) 250

Then lord Apollo, the archer, replied: "O father, you, who scoff at me for being the only one who is fond of booty, are now going to hear a tale that is irrefutable. After journeying for a long time in the mountains of Cyllene I found a child, this

out-and-out robber here; as sharp a rogue I have not seen either among gods or 260
 mortals who cheat their fellows on earth. He stole my cows from the meadow in
 the evening and proceeded to drive them along the shore of the loud-sounding
 sea making directly for Pylos. The tracks were of two kinds, strange and marvel-
 ous, the work of a clever spirit. The black dust retained the prints of the cattle
 and showed them leading into the asphodel meadow. But this rogue I have
 here, an inexplicable wonder, did not cross the sandy ground on his feet or
 on his hands; but by some other means he smeared the marks of his amazing
 course as though someone had walked on oak saplings. As long as he followed
 the cattle across the sandy ground, the tracks stood out very clearly in the dust.
 But when he had covered the great stretch of sand, his own course and that of 270
 the cows quickly became imperceptible on the hard ground. But a mortal man
 noticed him driving the herd of cattle straight for Pylos. When he had quietly
 penned up the cows and slyly confused his homeward trail by zigzagging this
 way and that, he nestled down in his cradle, obscure as the black night, within
 the darkness of the gloomy cave, and not even the keen eye of an eagle would
 have spied him. He kept rubbing his eyes with his hands as he devised his subtle
 wiles, and he himself immediately maintained without a qualm: 'I have not seen
 a thing, I do not know a thing and I have not heard a word from anyone. I cannot
 give information nor can I win the reward.'" Thus Phoebus Apollo spoke and
 then sat down. (333–365) 280

And Hermes in answer told his side of the story, directing his words point-
 edly to Zeus, the ruler of all the gods. "Father Zeus, I shall indeed tell you the
 truth. For I am honest and I do not know how to lie. He came to our house today
 as the sun was just rising, in search of his shambling cattle. He brought none
 of the blessed gods as witnesses or observers and with great violence ordered
 me to confess; he made many threats of hurling me down into wide Tartarus,
 since he is in the full bloom of his glorious prime, while I was born only yesterday
 (as he too well knows himself) and do not look at all like a cattle rustler or a man
 of brawn. Believe me (for you claim to be my own dear father too) that I did not
 drive his cows home nor even cross the threshold—so may I prosper, what I tell 290
 you is the truth. I deeply revere Helios and the other gods; I love you and I am in
 dread of this fellow here. You know yourself that I am not guilty—I shall swear a
 great oath besides—no, by these beautifully ornate portals of the gods. Some-
 how, someday, I will pay him back, even though he is mighty, for his ruthless be-
 havior. Be on the side of a defenseless baby." Thus the Cyllenian slayer of Argus
 spoke, blinking in innocence, and he held his baby blanket on his shoulder and
 would not let it go. (366–388)

Zeus gave a great laugh as he saw the devious child knowingly and cleverly
 make his denials about the cattle. He ordered the two of them to act in accord
 and make a search; Hermes, in his role of guide, was to lead without any mali- 300
 cious intent and point out the spot where he had hidden away the mighty herd
 of cattle. The son of Cronus nodded his head and splendid Hermes obeyed, for
 the will of aegis-bearing Zeus easily persuaded him. (389–396)

THE RECONCILIATION BETWEEN HERMES AND APOLLO

The two very beautiful sons of Zeus hastened together to sandy Pylos, crossed
 the river Alpheus, and came to the lofty cave where the animals were sheltered
 in the nighttime. Then, while Hermes went into the rocky cavern and drove the



mighty head of cattle out into the light, the son of Leto looked away and noticed the cowhides on the steep rock and immediately asked glorious Hermes: “O sly rogue, how were you, a newborn infant, able to skin two cows? I do indeed wonder at the strength that will be yours in the future; there is no need to wait for you to grow up, O Cyllenian, son of Maia.” (397–408) 310

Thus he spoke and fashioned with his hands strong bonds out of willow.⁷ But they grew up in that very spot on the ground under their feet; and twisting and twining together, they readily covered over all the cattle of the field at the will of the trickster Hermes, while Apollo watched in wonder. Then the mighty slayer of Argus looked away to the ground, fire flashing from his eyes, in his desire to get out of his predicament. But it was very easy for him, just as he wished, to soften the far-shooting son of Leto, even though he was strong; he took up the lyre in his left hand and tried it by striking successive notes. The instrument resounded in startling fashion, and Phoebus Apollo laughed with delight as the lovely strains of the heavenly music pierced his being, and sweet yearning took hold of his heart while he listened. (409–423) 320

The son of Maia, growing bold as he played so beautifully, took his stand on the left side of Phoebus Apollo and began to sing a song—and lovely was the ensuing sound of his voice—fashioned on the theme of the immortal gods and the dark earth and how in the beginning they came into being and how each was allotted his due. Of the gods he honored first of all Mnemosyne, mother of the Muses, for she honored him, the son of Maia, as one of her own. The splendid son of Zeus paid tribute to each of the other immortal gods according to age and birth, mentioning all in the proper order, as he played the lyre on his arm. (423–433) 330

But an irresistible desire took hold of Apollo, heart and soul, and he spoke up, interrupting with winged words: “Cattle slayer, contriver, busy worker, good companion at a feast, this skill of yours is worth fifty cows—I think that we soon will be peacefully reconciled. Come now, tell me, ingenious son of Maia, was this wonderful achievement yours from birth, or did one of the gods or mortal humans give you this noble gift and teach you inspired song? For this newly uttered sound I hear is wonderful, and I tell you that no one, either mortal or god who dwells on Olympus, has ever before known it, except you, you trickster, son of Zeus and Maia. What skill! What Muse’s art! What salve for sorrow and despair! It gives the choice of three blessings together all at once: joy and love and sweet sleep. I follow the Olympian Muses who delight in dancing, the swelling beat of music, and the lovely tune of flutes, yet never have I been as thrilled at young men’s feasts by such clever delights as these. I marvel, O son of Zeus, at your charming playing. Since you know such a glorious skill, even though you are little, sit down, my boy, and listen to what I intend. For you yourself and your mother will have renown among the immortal gods. And I shall vow this to you truly: By this spear of cornel wood, I shall make you a renowned and prosperous guide among the immortal gods, and I shall give you splendid gifts and to the end I shall not deceive you.” (434–462) 340

Hermes answered him with clever words: “Archer-god, your questions are well considered; I do not begrudge your taking up my art. You will know it this very day. I want us to be friends, alike in what we think and what we say. You know all things in your heart, for you, son of Zeus, sit in the first place among the immortals, brave and strong. Zeus in his wisdom loves you as he rightly should and has granted you splendid gifts. And they say that you have acquired from 350

the mouth of Zeus honors and, O archer-god, from him too every kind of divine oracular power. I know then that you are very rich in these gifts and you have only to make the choice of whatever you desire to learn. So, since your heart is set on playing the lyre, sing and play and be merry; accept this gift from me; and you, my dear friend, bestow glory upon me. With this clear-voiced companion in your hands,⁸ sing beautifully and well, knowing the art of proper presentation. Then with confidence take it to a luxurious feast and lovely dance and splendid revel, a thing of joy both night and day. Whoever makes demands of it after acquiring skill and knowledge is informed with sounds of every sort to delight the mind, for it is played by gentle familiarity and refuses to respond to toilsome drudgery. And whoever through lack of skill is from the first vehement in his demands is answered in return with wild and empty notes that clang upon the air. But you have only to make the choice of learning whatever you desire. To you I give this gift, splendid son of Zeus, and we both shall feed the cattle of the field on the pastures in the mountain and the plain where horses also graze. Even you, shrewd bargainer that you are, ought not to be violently angry.” (463–495)

With these words he held out the lyre, and Phoebus Apollo accepted it. And he entrusted to Hermes the shining whip that he had and put him in charge of cattle herds. The son of Maia accepted this with joy. The far-shooting lord Apollo, the glorious son of Leto, took the lyre in his left hand and tried it by striking successive notes. It sounded in startling fashion at his touch, and the god sang a beautiful song in accompaniment. (496–502)

Afterward the two of them turned the cows out into the sacred meadow, and they, the very beautiful sons of Zeus, hastened back to snow-capped Olympus, all the while taking delight in the lyre. Zeus in his wisdom was pleased and united them both in friendship; Hermes has loved the son of Leto steadfastly, and he still does even now, as is evident from the pledges made when Hermes entrusted his lovely lyre to the archer-god and Apollo took it on his arm and learned how to play. But Hermes himself fashioned another instrument and learned another art, producing the sound of pipes that are heard from afar.⁹ (503–512)

Then the son of Leto said to Hermes, “I fear, cunning guide, that you may steal my lyre and my curved bow; for you have from Zeus the prerogative of establishing the business of barter among people on the nourishing earth. Yet if, for my sake, you would deign to swear the great oath of the gods, either by a nod of your head or by the mighty waters of the river Styx, you would do everything that would satisfy my heart’s desire.” Then the son of Maia nodded and promised that he would never steal a thing from all that the far-shooter possessed and that he would never come near his mighty house. In turn Apollo, the son of Leto, nodded in loving friendship that no one else among mortals

would be more dear, neither god nor mortal sprung from Zeus, and said, “I shall pledge that this bond between us will be trusted and honored both in my heart and that of all the gods. Besides, I will give you in addition a very beautiful golden staff of prosperity and wealth, three-branched and protective; it will keep you safe while, in the name of all the gods, you accomplish by word and by deed the good things which I declare that I learn from the divine voice of Zeus. (513–532)

“As for this gift of prophecy which you mention, O best of Zeus’ sons, it is not allowed by god that you or any other of the immortals learn what the mind of Zeus knows; but I have pledged, vowed, and sworn a mighty oath that no other one of the eternal gods (apart from me) should know the infinite wisdom



Hermes. Attic red-figure cup by the Euaion painter, ca. 460 B.C. Hermes stands with his attributes of petasus, caduceus, and winged boots. He wears the traveler’s cloak and is bearded. Compare Giambologna’s bronze, page 291. (Louvre, Paris, France)

of Zeus. You, my brother, with your rod of gold, do not bid me reveal any of the divine plans which far-seeing Zeus is devising. I shall hurt some and help others, as I cause great perplexity for the masses of unhappy human beings. The person will profit from my utterance who comes under the guidance of the flight and the cry of my birds of true omen. This is the one who will profit from my utterance and whom I will not deceive; but the one who trusts the birds of meaningless chatter will seek to find out my prophecies and to know more than the eternal gods, quite against my will. I declare that for this one the journey will be in vain, but I would take his gifts anyway. (533–549)

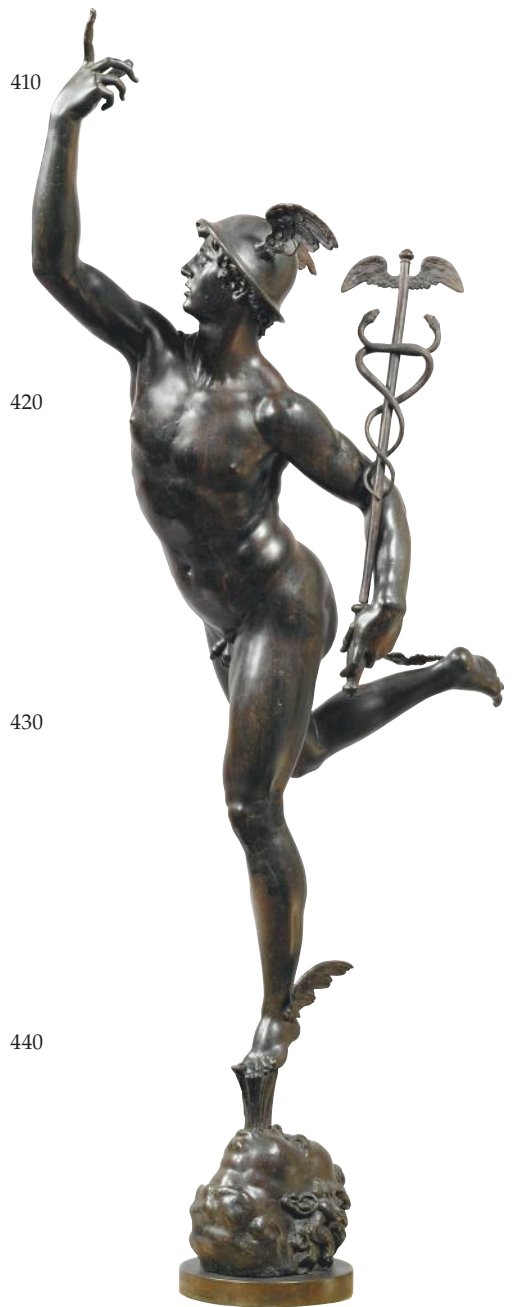
“I shall tell you another thing, son of illustrious Maia and aegis-bearing Zeus, O divine luck-bringer of the gods: indeed, certain holy sisters have been born, three virgins, glorying in their swift wings and having on their heads a sprinkling of white barley, and they live under a ridge of Mt. Parnassus;¹⁰ set apart, they are masters of divination, an art I practiced while still a lad tending cattle and my father did not mind. Then from their home they fly from one place to another and feed from every honeycomb until it is empty. When they have eaten the yellow honey, they become inspired and willingly desire to speak the truth; but if they are deprived of the sweet food of the gods, they gather in a swarm and tell lies. These sisters I give to you; inquire of them carefully and take pleasure in your heart. If then you inform mortal persons, they will listen to what you say often, if they are fortunate. Have these things, son of Maia, and care for the horned oxen of the field, the toiling mules and the horses.” (550–568)

Thus he spoke, and from heaven father Zeus himself added a final pledge to his words: he ordered that glorious Hermes be the lord of all birds of good omen, fierce-eyed lions, boars with gleaming tusks, dogs, and every flock and herd that the wide earth nourishes; and that he alone would be the ordained messenger to Hades, who, although he accepts no gifts, will grant this, by no means the least of honors. (569–573)

So lord Apollo loved the son of Maia in an all-encompassing friendship; and Zeus, the son of Cronus, bestowed on him a beguiling charm. He associates with mortals and immortals. On occasion he gives profit or help to a few, but for the most part he continually deceives human beings by the horde in the blackness of night. (574–578)

So hail to you, son of Zeus and Maia; yet I shall remember both you and another song too.

This artful hymn to Hermes has been much admired; the English poet Percy Bysshe Shelley (1792–1822) himself was one of its translators. The glib and playful treatment of both Hermes and Apollo is often labeled typically Greek.¹¹ It is typically Greek only if we mean by typical *one* of the many brilliant facets of Hellenic genius and a suggestion of the wide variety and scope in the conception of deity. Sincere profundity in religion and philosophy are as typically Greek as wit and facetious sophistication.



Mercury, by Giovanni Bologna (known as Giambologna, 1529–1608); bronze, 1576; height 25 in. Giambologna has taken the classical attributes of Hermes—the petasus, caduceus, and winged sandals—and combined them with the nude figure of a running man to create a masterpiece of Late Renaissance Mannerism. (Alinari/Art Resource, NY)

The Nature of Hermes and His Worship

Many of Hermes' characteristics and powers are evident from the poem. The Greek admiration for cleverness is readily apparent; it is this same admiration that condones the more dubious traits of the hero Odysseus. Anthropomorphism and liberalism are both pushed to their extreme in the depiction of the god Hermes as a thief and in the implication that thieves too must have their patron deity. Divine Hermes, like Prometheus, represents another (albeit extreme) example of the **archetypal trickster**. Yet in delightful, archetypal variations, the major quest of this charming young rogue is extremely dubious—a robbery—and, moreover, is accomplished when he is only a little baby!

The similarities between Hermes and Apollo are equally apparent. They share pastoral and musical characteristics, and the origins of both were probably rooted in the same pastoral society of shepherds with their interest in flocks, music, and fertility. The Sicilian shepherd **Daphnis** was the son of Hermes and a nymph and became the inventor of pastoral music and a leading character in the pastoral poetry of Theocritus. Hermes and Apollo are alike in appearance, splendid examples of vigorous and handsome masculinity. But Hermes is the younger and more boyish, the idealization and patron of youths in their late teens; his statue belonged in every gymnasium. Hermes is perhaps best known as the divine messenger, often delivering the dictates of Zeus himself; as such he wears a traveler's hat (**petasus**) and sandals (**talaria**) and carries a herald's wand (**caduceus**), which sometimes bears two snakes entwined. The entwined snakes may be a symbol for Hermes as a fertility god, connected with the Underworld. The staff of Hermes became confused with the staff of the physician Asclepius, for whom serpents represented new life, since they could slough their old skins (see p. 262). Wings may be depicted on Hermes' hat, his sandals, and even his wand. Thus he is also the god of travelers and roads. As the guide of souls (**psychopompos**) to the realm of Hades under the earth, he provides another important function, which reminds us once again of his fertility connections.

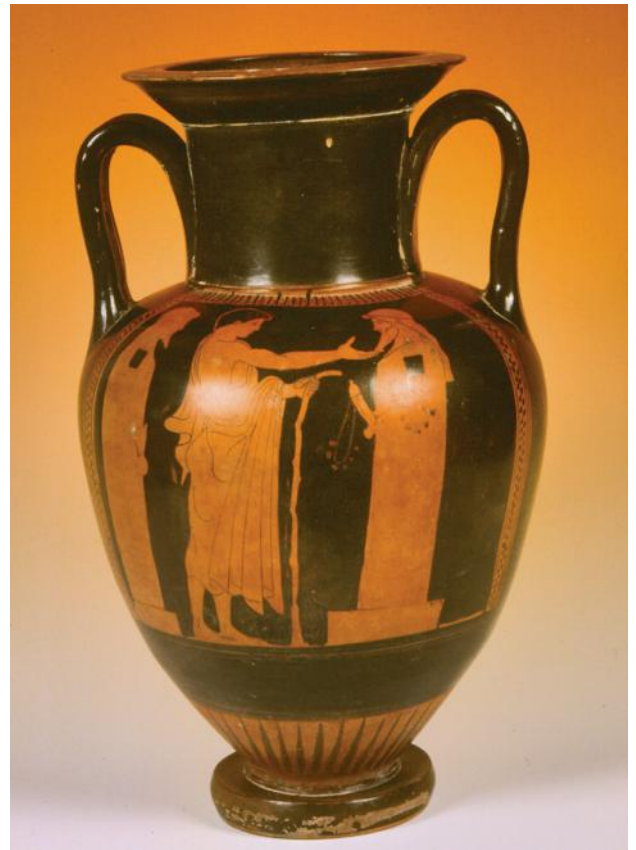
Statues of Hermes, called herms (singular, herm), were common in the ancient world and were symbols of fertility. They were intended to bring prosperity

The Mutilation of the Herms

Many ancient Greeks did believe in their gods. A historical incident concerning herms warns us to be wary of facile generalizations about Greek religious attitudes. In 415 B.C., on the eve of the great Athenian expedition against Sicily, the herms in the city of Athens were mutilated during the night. The religious scandal that ensued became a political football; the general Alcibiades was charged, and the consequences were serious—quite a fuss over phallic statues of a god in a period fraught with sophistic skepticism, agnosticism, and atheism. Alcibiades was also charged with the parody and desecration of the Eleusinian mysteries of Demeter in a private home; he called himself Hierophant and wore a robe like that of the high priest when he shows the holy secrets to the initiates (Plutarch, *Alcibiades* 22. 3; see also Thucydides 6. 27–29).

and luck. In the classical period, a herm might be found outside any house; and these herms could be taken very seriously. In appearance, they were square pillars equipped with male genitals; on top of each was the head of Hermes. These phallic statues probably marked areas regarded as sacred or designated, at least originally, the bounds of one's home or property.

Nilsson's theory about the origins of Hermes and his depiction as a herm is of interest.¹² There were various stone cults in Greece such as the one at Delphi in connection with the omphalos. It was believed that a divine power (*daimon*) resided in the stone, which was anointed and covered with sacred wool (see p. 251). On the top of a grave mound, which was often composed of lesser stones, a tall stone was erected. Passersby would add their stones to the mound, making it a guiding landmark. The god Hermes, whose name means "he from the stone-heap," was believed to live in this landmark grave-mound, and so he became the guide and protector of travelers and also of souls on their way to the Underworld. Subsequently,



Hermes. Athenian red-figure krater (left) and red-figure amphora by the Pan painter (right), both 470–460 B.C. These images show how Hermes and his phallic statues were part of the life of ordinary citizens at Athens. On the left a young woman clasps the shoulders of the god to whom she prays, perhaps before offering a simple sacrifice on the altar beside the herm. On the right a young man, standing between two herms and touching the god's beard in a traditional gesture of supplication, offers a garland and a prayer, perhaps before going on a journey. The god is the object of humble prayers for success, be it in love or business or travel. (Left: *Bildarchiv Preussischer Kulturbesitz/Art Resource, NY*) (Right: *Musée d'Art et d'Archéologie de Laon*)

Hermes Trismegistus

Hermes came to be equated with the Egyptian god Thoth and thus began to acquire some of his attributes as a god of magic, knowledgeable in things mystic and occult. In this transformation, he was given the epithet Trismegistus, which means thrice great (an appellation denoting a superlative, “great, great, great”). Hermes Trismegistus (supposedly the grandson of Hermes the god and not the god himself) is said to have composed many books on various aspects of Egyptian religion. The extant corpus of works attributed to him is referred to as the *Hermetica* (*Discourses of Hermes*) or *Hermetic Writings*. Topics deal with philosophy, astrology, and alchemy and despite some Egyptian influence are essentially Greek in character. These texts belong to the Hellenistic period (in the fourth century) after the time of Plato, whose influence is evident.

his abode, a monumental stone on a stone-heap, was regarded as his image (a herm) and given a human head. A herm never became fully anthropomorphic, and it continued to offer guidance for travelers and protection for graves, roads, and streets, and also to provide many blessings for homes.

To sum up, many of the functions of Hermes can be characterized by his role as a creator and crosser of boundaries and an intermediary between two different worlds. His herms served to mark the boundaries between one’s property and that of another and what has to be bridged. As a messenger of the gods, Hermes joins the human with the divine realm of the Olympians; as psychopompos, he brings mortals across the barriers of the Underworld. As a god of young men, Hermes stands as an exemplar of the critical rite of passage between youth and adulthood. Finally, in relation to Hermes and the crossing of established boundaries, consider the story of Hermaphroditus, a figure who unites the attributes of both sexes but transgresses the limitations of gender.

Hermaphroditus and Salmacis

Among the adventures and affairs of Hermes, his union with Aphrodite is important because of their offspring, Hermaphroditus, whose story is told by Ovid (*Metamorphoses* 4. 285–388):

Let me tell you how the fountain Salmacis got its bad reputation and why it weakens and softens limbs touched by its enervating waters.¹³ This power of the fountain is very well known; the reason for it lies hidden. A son was born to Mercury and Venus, and Naiads brought him up in the cave of Mt. Ida. You could recognize his mother and father in his beauty, and his name also came from them. As soon as he reached the age of fifteen, he left the hills of his homeland. When he had departed from Ida, the mountain that had nurtured him, he took delight in wandering over unknown lands and in seeing unknown rivers; his zeal made the hardships easy. (285–295)

Then he came to the cities of the Lycians and their neighbors the Carians. 10
 There he saw a pool of water that was clear to the very bottom with no marsh
 reeds, barren sedge, or sharp-pointed rushes to be seen. The water was trans-
 parent in its clarity, and the edge of the pool was surrounded by fresh turf and
 grass that was always green. (296–301)

A nymph lived here; but one who was not inclined to hunt and not in the habit
 of bending the bow or contending in the chase. She alone of the Naiads was
 unknown to swift Diana. It is told that her sisters often said to her: “Salmacis,
 take up a javelin or a lovely painted quiver; vary the routine of your idleness with
 the strenuous exercise of the hunt.” She did not take up the javelin or the lovely
 painted quiver and did not vary the routine of her idleness with the strenuous 20
 exercise of the hunt. Instead she would only bathe her beautiful limbs in her
 fountain and often comb out her hair with a comb of boxwood and look into
 the water to see what suited her best; and then she would clothe her body in a
 transparent garment and recline on the soft leaves or the soft grass. Often she
 picked flowers. (302–315)

Hermaphroditus

Ovid’s narrative of Salmacis and Hermaphroditus has dominated the literary and artistic tradition, obscuring the factual account of the first-century B.C. author Vitruvius, who explained the weakness caused by the pool of Salmacis as an allegory for the civilizing of local tribes by Greek settlers. Ovid’s source was a collection of tales from Asia Minor, one of them concerning Salmacis, a pool near Halicarnassus in Caria, beside which was a temple dedicated to Hermes and Aphrodite. The name Hermaphroditus was first used by the philosopher Theophrastus in about 320 B.C., describing how on the fourth and seventh days of the month (the fourth day was sacred to Hermes and Aphrodite) the superstitious man “spends all day putting wreaths on the Hermaphrodites.” By this time Hermaphroditus was worshiped as a god embodying the union of Hermes, with his erect phallus (see p. 293), and Aphrodite, as the physical expression of female fertility. He was, then, a minor fertility god, described by the historian Diodorus Siculus in the first century B.C. as “very like Priapus” (see p. 192), but his reputation received a boost from Polycles’ statue (which was said to have “made him noble”). Nevertheless, Ovid’s story, with its explicit focus on emasculation and physical weakness, has concealed whatever divine authority Hermaphroditus may once have held, and at Rome hermaphrodites were considered to be ill-omened prodigies and were drowned. Bisexuality is significant in Greek mythology and philosophy, as it is in nature. In the Orphic hymns Phanes, the original creator of everything, is bisexual. In Plato’s *Symposium*, Aristophanes explains how Zeus divided human beings into three sexes, with each individual seeking its other half (see pp. 209–212). These serious religious and philosophical allegories gave way to voyeuristic interest in bisexual human beings, furthered in literature by Ovid’s tale and in art by such works as the sculpture on p. 296. From Ovid came countless poetic elaborations from Spenser to Swinburne, while eighty artistic representations survive from the ancient world. Essential reading for Hermaphroditus is the article (in English) by Aileen Ajootian in *Lexikon Iconographicum Mythologiae Classicae*, Vol. 1, pp. 269–285.

Salmacis was picking flowers as it happened when she saw the boy Hermaphroditus. As soon as she saw him, she desired to have him. Although she was anxious to hasten to him, she did not approach until she had composed herself, arranged her garment, and assumed a beautiful countenance. When she looked as attractive as she ought, she began to speak as follows: “Lovely boy, most worthy to be believed a god; if you are a god, you could be Cupid; if a mortal, blessed are your parents, and happy your brother and fortunate indeed your sister, if you have one, and the nurse who gave you her breast. But by far the most blessed of all is your betrothed, if she exists, whom you will consider worthy of marriage. If you have such a beloved, let my passion be satisfied in secret, but if you do not, let me be the one and let us go together to our marriage bed.” With this the nymph was silent. (315–329)



A Hermaphrodite. Roman marble copy of a Greek bronze by Polykles of the mid-second century B.C.: marble mattress added by Gian-Lorenzo Bernini in 1620. Length 58 in. Hermaphrodites were popular from the fourth century onward in the Greek and (later) Roman worlds. The discovery of this one in Rome in 1608 led to fascination with the subject and the manufacture of many copies in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. It was presented to Cardinal Scipione Borghese, for whom Bernini made the mattress. The room in which it was displayed in his villa at Rome was later decorated with a fresco of the legend of Salmacis and Hermaphroditus. Napoleon (whose brother-in-law was a Borghese) bought the statue in 1807, and by 1811 it was on display in Paris, where it has remained. The male and female sexual attributes in the same figure have always intrigued viewers, while in the eighteenth century a cynical English tourist remarked that it was “the only happy couple that she ever saw.” (*Erich Lessing/ Art Resource, NY*)

A blush flared up in the boy's face, for he did not know what love was. But the flush of red was becoming; his was the color of apples hanging in a sunny orchard or of tinted marble or of the moon, a reddish glow suffusing its whiteness. . . . To the nymph, as she demanded without end at least the kisses of a sister and brought her hand to touch his ivory neck, he exclaimed: "Are you going to stop, or am I to flee and leave you and your abode?" Salmacis was frightened and replied: "I give over to you free access to this place, my guest and friend." She turned her step away and pretended to depart, though still with a glance back. She concealed herself in a hidden grove of bushes, dropping on bended knees. But he moved on the deserted grass from one spot to another, confident that he was not being watched and gradually dipped his feet as far as the ankles in the playful waves. (329–343) 40

Taken by the feel of the captivating waters, with no delay he threw off the soft clothes from his body. Then, to be sure, Salmacis was transfixed, enflamed with desire for his naked form. Her eyes, too, were ablaze just as if the radiant orb of the glowing sun were reflected in their mirror. With difficulty she endured the agony of waiting, with difficulty she held off the attainment of her joy. Now she longed to embrace him, now in her frenzy she could hardly contain herself. He swiftly struck his hollow palms against his sides and plunged into the pool, and as he moved one arm and then the other he glistened in the limpid water like an ivory statue or a lily that one has encased within clear glass. The nymph cried out: "I have won, he is mine!" And she flung off all her clothes and threw herself into the middle of the waves. She held him as he fought and snatched kisses as he struggled; she grasped him with her hands and touched his chest and now from this side and now from that enveloped the youth. (344–360) 50 60

Finally, she encircled him as he strove against her in his desire to escape, like a serpent which the king of birds has seized and carried aloft, and which as it hangs binds the eagle's head and feet and with its tail enfolds the spreading wings, even as ivy is wont to weave around tall trunks of trees or as the octopus grabs and holds fast its enemy in the deep with tentacles let loose on every side. Hermaphroditus, the descendant of Atlas, endured and denied the nymph the joys that she had hoped for. She continued her efforts, and her whole body clung to him as though they were glued together. She cried: "You may fight, cruel villain, but you will not escape. May the gods so ordain and may we never be separated in future time, you from me or me from you." The gods accepted her prayer. (361–373) 70

For their two bodies were joined together as they entwined, and in appearance they were made one, just as when one grafts branches on a tree and sees them unite in their growth and become mature together; thus, when their limbs united in their close embrace, they were no longer two but a single form that could not be called girl or boy and appeared at the same time neither one, but both. And so, when he saw that the limpid waters into which he had gone as a man had made him half a man and in them his limbs had become enfeebled, Hermaphroditus stretched out his hands and prayed in a voice that was no longer masculine: "Father and mother, grant this gift to your son who bears both your names. Let whatever man who enters this pool come out half a man and let him suddenly become soft when touched by its waves." Both parents were moved and granted the wish of their child, who was now of a double nature, and they tainted the waters with this foul power. (373–388) 80

Statues of Hermaphroditus and hermaphrodites became common in the fourth century and in the following Hellenistic period, when Greek masters strove to vary their repertoires with fascinating and brilliantly executed studies in the realistic, erotic, and unusual.

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Homeric Hymn 18	<i>To Hermes</i>
Ovid	<i>Metamorphoses</i> 4.285–388

Additional Sources

Lucian	<i>Dialogues of the Gods: Hermes and Maia</i>
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The following are ancient sources for the historical incidents of the mutilation of the Herms, the desecration of the Mysteries, and the charges against Alcibiades and others.

Andocides	<i>On the Mysteries</i>
Thucydides	<i>History of the Peloponnesian War</i> 6.27.1–6.29.3

Notes

1. The live tortoise was believed to be a taboo against harm and sorcery.
2. This is probably the well-known Pieria near Mt. Olympus in northern Thessaly. On his journey from Pieria, Hermes passes through Onchestus, situated between Thebes and Orchomenus, and brings the cattle to the river Alpheus, which flows near Olympia in the western Peloponnesus.
3. As he walks along, Hermes makes the cattle walk backward. Thus the hoofprints of the cattle will seem to be going toward the meadow and not out of it. Hermes' own tracks will be obscured by his sandals.

4. As we have seen, according to Hesiod (*Theogony* 387), Selene is the daughter of Hyperion and Theia; Pallas (*Theogony* 375, 377, 409) was the son of the Titan Crius; and his brother Perses was the father of Hecate. Megamedes is not found elsewhere.
5. The text is corrupt at this point; apparently, Hermes used the laurel branch to rub against a piece of wood grasped in the palm of his hand, thus creating the friction to produce fire.
6. Hermes offers a portion to each of the twelve gods. According to sacrificial ritual, he (as one of them) must not eat his portion or those of the other gods but merely savor the aroma.
7. Presumably Apollo intends to bind either Hermes or the cows.
8. The lyre is mentioned as a beloved companion, that is, a girlfriend, and in the next few lines Hermes sustains the metaphor, which reads naturally in Greek but is difficult to render in English. Thus she will accompany Apollo to the feast and the dance, and she will behave and respond as a beloved should, if only she is treated in the right way.
9. These are shepherds' pipes of reed, also called panpipes since they are often said to be the invention of the god Pan. Hermes sometimes is named as the father of Pan, whom he resembles in certain respects.
10. These are identified as the Thriae; their name means "pebbles." Thus they are the eponymous nymphs of divining pebbles, that is, pebbles used for divination. They appear to be women with wings. Probably their hair is literally powdered with white flour; some suggest that they are meant to be white-haired and old or that the image intended is that of bees covered with pollen.
11. In tone and mood, this story is not unlike that of Aphrodite, Ares, and Hephaestus in Homer (*Odyssey* 8. 266–366, translated in Chapter 5, pp. 128–130).
12. See Martin P. Nilsson, *A History of Greek Religion*. Translated by F. J. Fielden. 2d. ed. New York: W. W. Norton, 1952 [1964], pp. 109–110.
13. In context, Alcithoë is telling the story to her sisters. The spring Salmacis was located at Halicarnassus.



Dionysus, Pan, Echo, and Narcissus

Reenactment of the Marriage of Dionysus and Ariadne When Dionysus cast his eyes upon her, he danced over to her and like a lover sat upon her lap. He took her in his arms and kissed her. Ariadne behaved modestly, but nevertheless she lovingly embraced him. When the party-guests beheld this, they kept applauding and shouting for an encore. And when Dionysus got up and drew Ariadne up with him, then you could see a real performance, as they proceeded to kiss and fondle one another. The audience saw a very good-looking Dionysus and a gorgeous Ariadne not playing a role but truly kissing each other and they all watched with great excitement. . . . In the end the dinner guests seeing the couple embracing and moving off to their marriage-bed, the unmarried ones vowed to get married, those who were already married got on their horses and rode off to visit their wives.

—XENOPHON, *Symposium* 9.4–7

The Birth, Childhood, and Origins of Dionysus

The traditional account of the birth of Dionysus (Bacchus)¹ runs as follows. Disguised as a mortal, Zeus was having an affair with **Semele**, a daughter of **Cadmus**. When Hera found out, her jealousy led her to get even. She appeared to Semele disguised as an old woman and convinced her rival that she should ask her lover to appear in the full magnificence of his divinity. Semele first persuaded Zeus to swear that he would grant whatever she might ask of him, and then she revealed her demand. Zeus was unwilling but was obliged to comply, and Semele was burned to a cinder by the splendor of his person and the fire of his lightning flash. The unborn child, being divine, was not destroyed in the conflagration; Zeus saved his son from the ashes of his mother and sewed him up in his own thigh, from which he was born again at the proper time.²

Various nurses are associated with the infant Dionysus, in particular certain nymphs of Nysa, a mountain of legendary fame located in various parts of the ancient world. Hermes, who had rescued Dionysus from Semele's ashes, carried the baby to the nymphs of Nysa. **Ino**, Semele's sister, is traditionally singled out as one who